

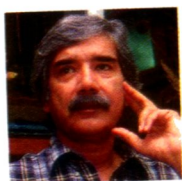
Sharks' TALE

A campaign launched by the Wildlife Trust of India has inspired fishermen on the Saurashtra coast to save the endangered whale shark

| By Uday Mahurkar |

In September last year, fisherman Amrutlal Chauhan and helpers spread their nets in the sea near the Saurashtra coast, hoping to catch some fish. But what got trapped in the net took them by surprise. It was a 20-ft whale shark. A timely call was made to the local 'Save Whale Shark' campaign activist Dinesh Goswami who along with personnel of the forest and fisheries departments came to the spot to cut the nets open and set the giant fish free.

Had a similar situation presented itself a few years back, Chauhan would have feasted with his family and friends after catching a barrel (a whale shark is called a barrel since it is caught with one). A local fish trader would shell out Rs 2 lakh for the giant fish, and in turn, export its meat and flanks. Sold at a high price in South-east Asian countries, the meat of the whale shark is a delicacy and the oil it yields is sold at Rs 500 a kg. A Wildlife Trust of India (WTI) survey reveals that over 500 whale sharks were hunted by fishermen on the Saurashtra coast in 2000.



MIKE PANDEY'S DOCUMENTARY ON THE WHALE SHARKS INSPIRED THE CAMPAIGN WHICH HAS RESULTED IN A REMARKABLE TURNAROUND.



Saving the whale shark is a remarkable turnaround story. Today, Chauhan is among thousands of fishermen on the Saurashtra and Kutch coast in Gujarat who are saving whale sharks, courtesy the Save Whale Shark campaign launched by the WTI and the International Fund for Animal Welfare (IFAW) in 2004. Since then, the fishermen have saved close to 100 whale sharks, releasing the giant fish soon after they are trapped.

The campaign is an example now,

involving a large cross-section of society including animal protection activists, government machinery, corporate entities like Tata Chemicals Ltd and Gujarat Heavy Chemical Ltd and leading figures. Says Dhiresh Joshi, coordinator of the Gujarat unit of WTI, "It is an awesome experience to see the gentle giant in front of your eyes."

WTI's masterstroke was involving the hugely popular Ramayana Kathakar Morari Bapu, whose mass appeal, particularly in Gujarat, is almost unmatched, as the brand ambassador of the campaign. In his first press conference in 2004 after joining the campaign, Bapu appealed to the fishermen, "Whale sharks come to the Saurashtra's coast to breed